

1950s American Culture: Paranoia, Suburbia, & Inequality

In the years following World War II, the United States became the world leader in industry and a global power. Culture in the 1950s is often seen as one of conformity, but several contradictions existed during the decade, some more visible than others.

Cold War & Red Scare - One defining element of 1950s culture was the ever-increasing tension between the Soviet Union and the United States. This tension grew out of fear in the US political sphere of communism. Euphemistically, leaders in the West, particularly in large capitalist countries like the United States, claimed that the USSR had "*expansive tendencies*." [...] Paranoia was at an all-time high during the Cold War Era, as many politicians believed that communists were hiding in plain sight among the American public. This paranoia took the form of 84 hearings in Congress between 1945 and 1952, a push by the House un-American Activities Committee (HUAC) to uncover communist threats in American political and entertainment figures. The HUAC uncovered little to nothing during these hearings but served to alienate and ostracize normal Americans in universities, public schools, the federal government, and even in Hollywood. The most intense form of this "Red Scare" came in the form of McCarthyism, wherein Senator Joseph McCarthy espoused supposed proof that "subversives" lurked in the upper echelons of government and were influencing the American public through entertainment. [...]

Growing affluence and the Levittown phenomenon - After the end of World War II, couples began having more babies than ever before, largely due to the security and relative peace they felt after four years of war. Nearly 4 million babies per year were born in the 1950s, meaning the population of the United States was growing, as was the economy. The economic uptick of the 1950s is often known as the "Golden Age of American Capitalism," as government spending led to citizen spending in turn. Infrastructure, veteran benefits, and new technology led to a growing middle class, one that was low in unemployment and high in wages. Middle-class Americans had more means and opportunities to spend than ever before, which included where they chose to live. Cities were growing crowded as the population boomed, and almost directly after the end of World War II, a solution began cropping up. Developers like William Levitt built sprawling, self-sufficient neighborhoods on the outskirts of cities, easily reachable with the growing network of highways in the country. [...]

Desegregation & rumblings of the Civil Rights Movement - Racial inequality was reaching a fever pitch in the 1950s, as even outside of the South, Black Americans were still being treated as lesser. This manifested in many ways, namely the exclusion of Black soldiers and their families from the Levittown phenomenon, as well as being segregated from white Americans in nearly all aspects of public life, from restaurants to buses to bathrooms. This frustration with inequality was the beginning of the Civil Rights Movement, which would begin to affect change in earnest in the 1960s and inspire groups like the Black Panthers and the Nation of Islam. [...]

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